

Ankylosaurs

Also known as the “armored dinosaurs” or “tank dinosaurs,” the members of this family were built like tanks. Their squat bodies were covered with defensive armor plates and spikes formed from bony growths that developed in the skin. Without this protection, these plant-eaters would have been at the mercy of much swifter and sometimes bigger carnivores.

Edmontonia

ED-mon-TOE-nee-a

- **When** 75–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 23 ft (7 m)
- **Diet** Low-growing plants

Edmontonia was twice the weight of a rhino and armed with huge spikes jutting out of its shoulders. Perhaps it drove off attackers by charging and lunging into them, using the spikes as spears. Some scientists think it used its lethal shoulder spikes to fight others of its own kind in battles over territory or mates.



Shoulder spike



Ankylosaurus

ANK-ill-oh-SORE-us

- **When** 70–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 20 ft (6 m)
- **Diet** Low-growing plants

Ankylosaurus was the largest ankylosaur ever. Hundreds of armor plates studded its thick skin, and small armor plates even covered its

eyelids. The armor formed from bony plates called osteoderms that grew within the skin, much like the armor plating of a crocodile's skin. *Ankylosaurus* was also equipped with a huge tail club that it could swing at attackers with bone-shattering force.



Bony plates on upper body

Soft underbelly

Long tail tipped with bony club



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Heavily armored bodies
- Walked on all fours
- Horny beak with teeth usually on lower jaw
- Some ankylosaurs had tail clubs and horns on the back of the head
- Others (known as nodosaurs) had large shoulder spikes

When

Ankylosaurs lived during the Jurassic and Cretaceous Periods.

